HANWEN ZHANG

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Research Interests

Primary: Macroeconomics; Macro-Finance.
Secondary: Monetary Policy; Household Finance; Heterogeneous-Agent Macroeconomics.

Education

Norwegian School of Economics, Norway 2021 – 2027 (expected)
Ph.D. in Economics *Parental leave: Aug 2024 – Jan 2025*
Supervisor: Krisztina Molnár. Co-supervisor: Markus Karlman.

University of Zurich, Switzerland 2019 – 2021
M.A. in Business and Economics, *Summa Cum Laude.*
Major: Economics; Minor: Economic Policy.

Southwestern University of Finance and Economics, China 2015 – 2019
B.Sc. in Finance; B.Sc. in Financial Management (bilingual)

References

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Davide Debortoli
ICREA Research Professor
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Job Market Paper

Who Reaches for Yield? (with Marek Jasinski)

Using Norwegian administrative data, we show that households at every level of liquid wealth reduce their risky share after a contractionary monetary policy shock, consistent with reaching for yield. The response is convex in wealth and flattens at the top. Portfolio flow inherits this gradient but moves differently: over the tightening phase, the wealthiest households buy equities while less affluent households sell. A model-free accounting identity that decomposes net purchases of risky assets shows why. On impact, capital losses offset the rebalancing withdrawal of the wealthiest and hold their flow near zero while households below them sell. By the trough of the contraction, net saving at the top turns the wealthiest into net buyers. We develop a theory of reaching for yield based on certainty-equivalent portfolio adjustment, in which monetary policy changes households' marginal utility but not their sensitivity to risk. Higher interest income raises effective risk aversion and lowers the risky share. The model generates the convex wealth gradient with countercyclical idiosyncratic disaster risk because the marginal utility of the wealthy is less sensitive to resource changes. Together, these forces explain why monetary tightening reduces risky exposure throughout the wealth distribution while reallocating equity ownership toward the top.

Presentation: NHH "Expectations and Macroeconomics" Workshop (2024); UPF Brown-Bag Seminar (2025); NHH Macroeconomics Seminar (2026).

Working Papers

Who Saves, Who Spends: The Wealth Distribution as a Stabilizer

The intertemporal transmission of fiscal and monetary policy depends on how a shock reshapes the saving distribution across households. I develop an analytical framework built from the household Euler equation that traces saving from optimization to policy multipliers. A first-order perturbation shows that marginal propensities to consume satisfy a recursion, and yields a three-step method for the consumption response to any shock. Aggregating, a heterogeneous-agent economy departs from a representative agent that matches its aggregate propensities to consume and save. The reason is simple: the households who accumulate the saving are not those who would spend it. In a two-period setting, closed-form multipliers reveal a structural asymmetry. For deficit-financed fiscal policy, heterogeneity unambiguously attenuates the multiplier: saving accumulates where it cannot be spent, and taxes fall where they cannot be smoothed. For monetary policy, the same forces cut both ways, so the sign is calibration-dependent.

Monetary Policy Transmission and the Reallocation of Risk

This paper asks how a monetary contraction reallocates risky assets across the wealth distribution. I build a heterogeneous-agent New Keynesian model with countercyclical probabilities of a rare, persistent idiosyncratic labor-income disaster and an endogenous choice between safe and risky assets, and show that the reaching-for-yield theory of Jasinski and Zhang (2026) can be embedded in the sequence-space method at the cost of a first-order solution: one scalar per date, the common belief about the price of risk, pins down the whole cross-section of portfolio adjustment. Disciplined by that paper's evidence, the model reproduces the cross-section of risky-share responses in general equilibrium; its convexity comes from an income channel that fades with wealth, and its flattening at the top from the wealthy's weak response to the price of risk and from the cyclical disaster probability. Equity is in fixed supply, so reallocation is zero-sum. On impact the households holding the bottom quarter of the stock sell 2.8 percent of their equity and the other three quarters buy, increasingly with wealth; cyclical tail risk accounts for a seventh of the trade. The trade is undone within two years, but in every variation of the aggregate block the bottom quarter ends with less of the stock and the quarter above it with more, by about 0.15 percent of their holdings five years on.

Research Experience

Universitat Pompeu Fabra, Spain Spring 2025
Visiting Researcher, hosted by Prof. Davide Debortoli.

University of Zurich, Switzerland 2020 – 2021
Graduate Research Assistant to Prof. Ulrich Woitek.

Teaching Experience

Norwegian School of Economics, Norway 2022 – 2026
Graduate Teaching Assistant: Macroeconomic Theory and Policy; Empirical Methods and Applications in Macroeconomics and Finance; Business Cycle Analysis and Macroeconomic Policies; Long-Term Macroeconomic Analysis.

University of Zurich, Switzerland Spring 2021
Graduate Teaching Assistant: MATLAB & Python in Quantitative Monetary Economics.

Technical Skills

Programming: Python; MATLAB and Dynare; Stata; R; LaTeX; Microsoft Office.
Languages: Mandarin Chinese (native), English (professional), German (beginner).